

China

AI and green-tech keep exports strong

Exports accelerated further in May, exceeding expectations amid a global manufacturing upswing. AI-related and green-tech goods remained key drivers, supported by the AI investment boom and energy shock-driven demand for renewables. Imports were lifted by higher commodity and electronics prices.

- **May: 19.4% y/y for exports, and 27.4% y/y for imports (both in USD terms)**
- **Bloomberg consensus (Barclays): 15% y/y (14%) for exports, and 26% y/y (25%) for imports**
- **April: 14.1% y/y for exports, and 25.3% y/y for imports (both in USD terms)**

China's export growth accelerated further, rising 19.4% y/y in May following a 14.1% increase in April, exceeding both the market and our expectations (Bloomberg: 15%, Barclays: 14%). Breakdown data suggest stronger shipments to the US and across the region (ASEAN, Korea, Japan and Taiwan), while shipments to the EU and UK softened. The robust performance came against the backdrop of 1) a continued uptick in global manufacturing activity, evidenced by the global manufacturing PMI holding at a four-year high of 52.6 in May despite the prolonged energy shock, and 2) broad-based strength across major manufacturing exporters, ranging from low-to-mid product exports from Vietnam (May: 18% y/y), to high-end oriented product exports from Korea (May: 53.2%), to the full-supply-chain exports from China (May: 19.4%).

Demand for high-tech products, particularly AI-related and green-tech goods, remained a key driver, helping to alleviate concerns over the impact of the Middle East energy shock on external demand. The ongoing global AI capex cycle continues to underpin demand for China's AI-related exports, given the country is a key supplier of AI manufactured components. High-tech exports accounted for 29.8% of total export value in May, growing 51% y/y (April: 39%), with notable acceleration in semiconductors (+111%) and automatic data processing equipment and parts (+66%). At the same time, the energy shock is supporting demand for renewable products, while persistent geopolitical tensions could further accelerate the global green transition, an area where China remains well positioned as a leading low-cost, high-quality supplier. Year-to-date data show sustained double-digit growth in EVs, lithium batteries, wind turbines, and solar cells.

Details of May export data

- **By destination:** Trade flows between the US and China are showing signs of continued normalization, with shipments to the US surging 35.4% y/y (April: 11.3%) partly helped by a low base a year earlier following the Liberation Day tariffs. On a sequential basis, exports to

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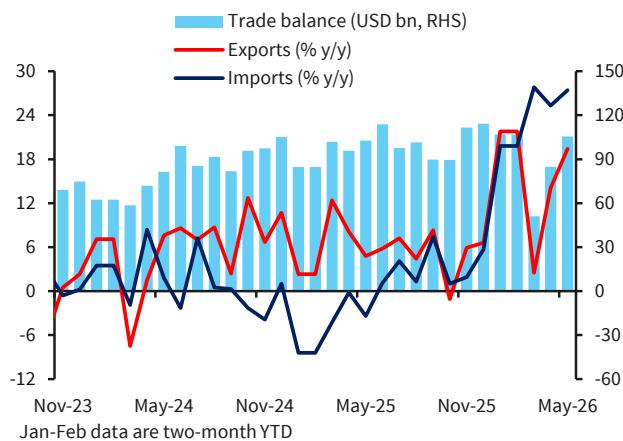
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the US rose by 6.2% m/m-better than the 2022-24 average of around 5.6% (excluding tariff-distorted dynamics in 2025)-pointing to recovery in shipment momentum. It contributed 3.2pp to headline export growth, well above the 1.2pp recorded in April. Meanwhile, regional exports to ASEAN (May: 24.3%, April: 15.2%) and to Japan, Korea and Taiwan (May: 27.5%, April: 16.8%) strengthened further. In contrast, export growth to the EU (May: 7.6%, April: 13.4%) and the UK (May: 1.7%, April: 9.6%) weakened. Moreover, shipments to Africa continued to expand at double-digit pace (May: 18.6%, April: 17.3%), while exports to LatAm softened.

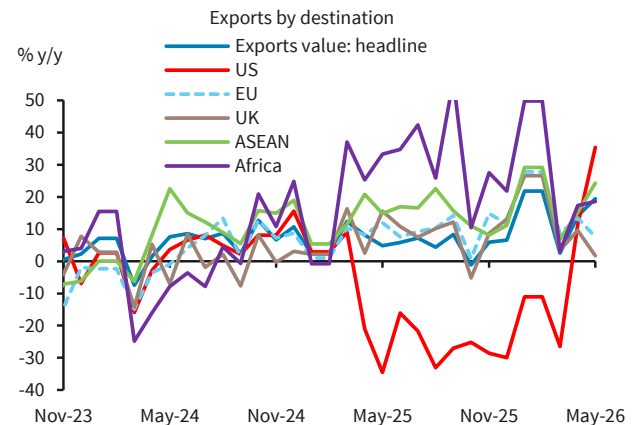
- **By product:** Most major export categories accelerated in May. Semiconductor exports value more than doubled from a year earlier, up 110.9% y/y following an already strong 99.6% increase in the previous month. Auto exports remained resilient, rising 39% y/y, although softening from the 44% increase in April. Exports of mechanical and electrical products grew 27.4% y/y, up from 20.3% previously, while home appliance exports continued to expand. Exports of furniture, general equipment and machinery also reversed to pick up in May.

FIGURE 1. China May exports accelerated...



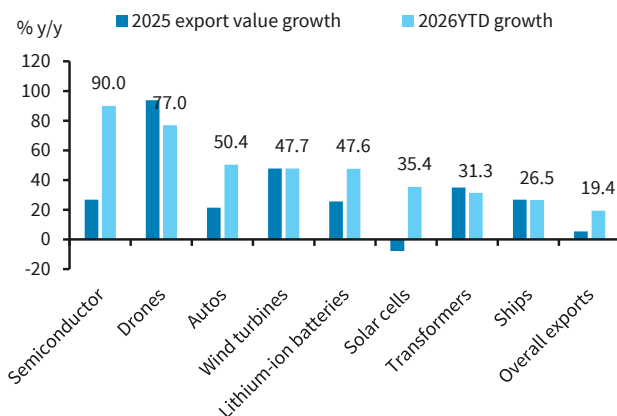
Source: Wind, Barclays Research

FIGURE 2. ... with faster regional trade (Asean, Japan, Korea and Taiwan) and shipments to the US



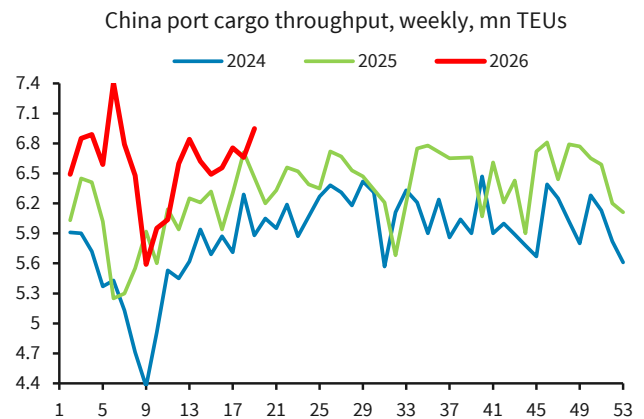
Source: Wind, Barclays Research

FIGURE 3. Strong exports were led by AI-related and green-tech products



Source: Wind, Barclays Research

FIGURE 4. High frequency shipping data showed still strong exports in early June



Source: Wind, Barclays Research

May headline imports posted a strong growth due to price effects

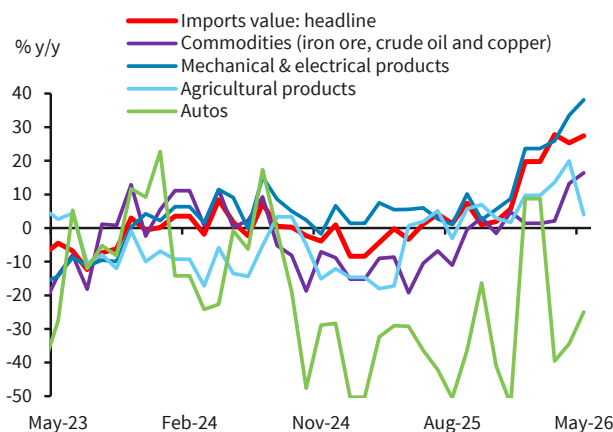
Imports have continued to exceed expectations this year. Against the backdrop of surging energy and semiconductor related prices, China's import value posted a solid growth of 27.4% y/y in May, following a 25.3% increase in April, supported by robust imports of mechanical and electrical products (May: 38.2%, April: 33.5%) and commodities (May: 16.4%, April: 13.3%). In contrast, imports of agricultural products softened, while auto imports remained weak, falling 25% y/y after a 34% decline previously.

On a volume basis, imports of energy-related products showed mixed developments. Crude oil imports fell at a faster pace of 29% y/y, following a 20% decline in April. Imports of coal continued to decline, but the pace moderated to -7.7% versus -12.5% previously. In contrast, natural gas imports stabilized after two consecutive months of double-digit declines (May: 0%; April: -12.9%). Market reports suggest a pickup in LNG purchases since mid-April¹, driven by expectations of stronger summer power demand, with momentum extending into June. Major buyers have stepped up purchases, increasing imports from Canada, Malaysia, and Russia to offset reduced LNG shipments from Qatar.

Imports of industrial materials showed mixed developments: iron ore import volume growth reversed to fall, while steel imports declined for a second month, though at a slower pace. In contrast, copper imports accelerated, up 4.4% versus 2.7% previously.

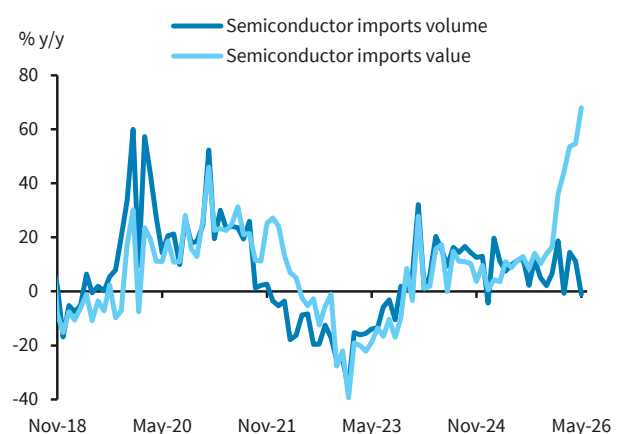
Import value of agricultural products rose by 4% following a 20% increase previously. China has agreed to expand agriculture trade with the US following the mid-May Trump–Xi summit, with the US readout noting purchases of at least USD17bn of US agricultural products annually in 2026–2028, on top of earlier soybean commitments. Soybean imports moderated, falling 10% (April: +49.3%) in value terms and 15% (April: +39.5%) in volume in May. That said, the import level of 11.79 million metric tons was still the second highest on record for the month, supported by strong Brazil supplies and faster customs clearance².

FIGURE 5. Imports of mechanical and electrical products accelerated...



Source: Wind, Barclays Research

FIGURE 6. ...with semiconductor import surging on a value basis

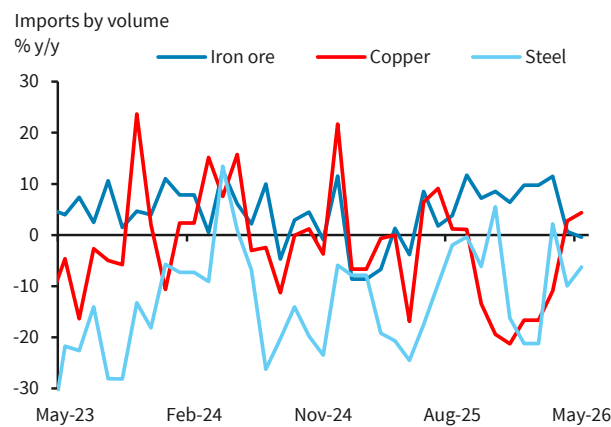


Source: Wind, Barclays Research

¹ "China Ramping Up LNG Buying in Anticipation of Summer Heat", Bloomberg, 8 June 2026

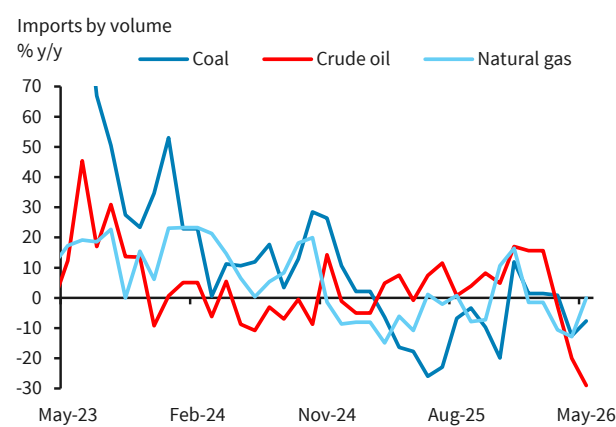
² "China's May soybean imports exceed expectations on strong Brazil supply, faster clearance", the Standard, 9 June 2026

FIGURE 7. Imports of steel and iron ore stayed soft



Source: Wind, Barclays Research

FIGURE 8. Imports of crude oil weakened further



Source: Wind, Barclays Research

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